Learn French for Beginners

French Dialogues

1 everyday conversation with pronunciation, vocabulary and questions

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Pronunciation key

Short everyday conversations between two people, each with its own recorded voice. Read and listen, take one of the roles, then check you understood.

Spelling	Sounds like
zh	the "s" in *measure* (French **j** / soft **g**)
uh	the "a" in *about*
ew	French **u**: say "ee" with your lips rounded like "oo"
N (capital)	nasal vowel: hum the vowel through your nose, don't say the "n"
ahN	nasal *an* / *en* (as in *France*)
ohN	nasal *on* (as in *bon*)
aN	nasal *in* / *ain* / *ien* (as in *vin*)
uhN	nasal *un* (as in *un*)
r	French throaty "r", made at the back of the throat
‿	liaison: the silent final consonant is pronounced at the start of the next word (*vous‿avez* = voo zah-vay)

The pronunciation under each line is an English-style respelling, not IPA: zh as in 'measure', uh as in 'the', ew as French u, a capital N for a nasal vowel (ahN, ohN, aN, uhN). ‿ links two words with a liaison: the consonant starts the next word (vous avez = voo‿zah-vay).

1. At the café (Au café) · A1

Scene: Camille walks into a small Paris café in the morning and sits at a table. Julien, the server, comes over to take her order. Later she asks for the bill and pays by card.

Julien, server · **Camille**, customer

Speaker	Line
Julien	**Bonjour, madame ! Vous avez choisi ?** *bohN-zhoor, mah-dahm. voo‿zah-vay shwah-zee* Hello! Have you decided?
Camille	**Bonjour ! Oui, je voudrais un café, s'il vous plaît.** *bohN-zhoor. wee, zhuh voo-dreh uhN kah-fay, seel voo pleh* Hello! Yes, I'd like a coffee, please.
Julien	**Un café. Et avec ça ?** *uhN kah-fay. ay ah-vek sah* A coffee. Anything else? (literally: and with that?)
Camille	**Un croissant aussi, s'il vous plaît.** *uhN krwah-sahN oh-see, seel voo pleh* A croissant too, please.
Julien	**Sur place ou à emporter ?** *sewr plahs oo ah ahN-por-tay* To eat in or to take away? (US: for here or to go?)
Camille	**Sur place, merci.** *sewr plahs, mair-see* Eat in, thanks.
Julien	**Très bien. Je vous apporte ça tout de suite.** *treh byaN. zhuh voo‿zah-port sah too duh sweet* Very good. I'll bring it to you right away.
Camille	**Excusez-moi ! L'addition, s'il vous plaît.** *eks-kew-zay mwah. lah-dee-syohN, seel voo pleh* Excuse me! The bill, please. (US: the check)
Julien	**Oui, bien sûr. Ça fait six euros cinquante.** *wee, byaN sewr. sah feh see‿zuh-roh saN-kahNt* Yes, of course. That's six euros fifty.
Camille	**Je peux payer par carte ?** *zhuh puh peh-yay par kart* Can I pay by card?
Julien	**Oui, pas de problème. Voilà. Bonne journée !** *wee, pah duh proh-blem. vwah-lah. bun zhoor-nay* Yes, no problem. Here you are. Have a nice day!
Camille	**Merci, au revoir !** *mair-see, oh ruh-vwahr* Thanks, goodbye!

Key vocabulary

French	Pronunciation	English	See
Vous avez choisi ?	*voo‿zah-vay shwah-zee*	Have you decided? / Ready to order?	choisir
je voudrais	*zhuh voo-dreh*	I'd like (polite)	Je voudrais…
un café	*uhN kah-fay*	a coffee (un: masculine)	Grammar tables: Indefinite articles: a, an, some

French	Pronunciation	English	See
Sur place ou à emporter ?	*sewr plahs oo ah ahN-por-tay*	Eat in or take away?	Sur place ou à emporter ?
je vous apporte	*zhuh voo‿zah-port*	I'll bring you	apporter
Excusez-moi	*eks-kew-zay mwah*	Excuse me	Excusez-moi
l'addition	*lah-dee-syohN*	the bill (US: the check)	L'addition, s'il vous plaît
six euros cinquante	*see‿zuh-roh saN-kahNt*	six euros fifty (€6.50)	Grammar tables: Numbers 21–100
Je peux payer par carte ?	*zhuh puh peh-yay par kart*	Can I pay by card?	Je peux payer par carte ?

Notice this: Vous: the polite 'you'

Julien and Camille don't know each other, so they both use vous, the polite 'you': Vous avez choisi ? and Je vous apporte ça. With a friend you would say tu: Tu as choisi ?

- **Vous avez choisi ?** *(voo‿zah-vay shwah-zee)* — *Have you decided? (polite)*
- **Tu as choisi ?** *(tew ah shwah-zee)* — *Have you decided? (to a friend)*

See the table: Grammar tables, Subject pronouns.

Comprehension questions

1. What does Camille order to drink?
   a. A coffee
   b. A hot chocolate
   c. A tea
   d. An orange juice
2. Where does Camille have her breakfast?
   a. At home
   b. In the café (eat in)
   c. On a park bench
   d. She takes it away
3. How much does Camille pay?
   a. €16.50
   b. €5.60
   c. €6.50
   d. €7.50
4. How does Camille ask for the bill?
   a. L'addition, s'il vous plaît.
   b. La carte, s'il vous plaît.
   c. Le menu, s'il vous plaît.
   d. Un café, s'il vous plaît.

Answer key

- 1.1 a) A coffee
- 1.2 b) In the café (eat in)
- 1.3 c) €6.50
- 1.4 a) L'addition, s'il vous plaît.

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